

May 2026



Full Planning Permission

DESIGN AND ACCESS STATEMENT

Demolition of Approved Barn Conversion (PA24-07287), Construction of 2 Replacement Dwellings & Associated Works

Barn E at Gwarnick Mill Farm, St Allen, Truro, TR4 9QU

Prepared By Cornwall Planning Group

HEAD OFFICE
Chi Gallos,
Hayle Marine Renewables Business Park,
North Quay, Hayle,
Cornwall, TR27 4DD

www.cornwallplanninggroup.co.uk
office@cornwallplanninggroup.co.uk
T: +44 (0)1736 448500



Registration No: 04345204
VAT No: 221707243

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1.0 Introduction

This planning application has been submitted to Cornwall Council in the form of full planning permission. The Design & Access Statement has been produced by Cornwall Planning Group on behalf of the client, Mr & Mrs T Burley. This Statement accompanies the associated plans and supporting documentation seeking permission for the demolition of the approved barn conversion under application reference PA24/07287 and the construction of 2 replacement dwellings with associated works at Barn E, Gwarnick Mill Farm, St Allen, Truro, TR4 9QU.

The principle of residential use on this site has already been firmly established through the granting of prior approval under Class Q permitted development rights. Importantly, the extant approval confirms the acceptability of residential conversion and the creation of two dwellings within the existing agricultural complex. This proposal therefore represents a logical and policy-compliant evolution of that fallback position, enabling a significantly more coherent, sustainable and design-led form of development to be delivered on the site.

Rather than pursuing the conversion of a large agricultural structure whose form and construction present limitations in terms of residential quality, environmental performance and architectural cohesion, the applicant is seeking to deliver a carefully considered replacement scheme that responds more appropriately to the rural character and established farmstead context of Gwarnick Mill Farm.

The proposed dwellings have been intentionally designed to retain the agricultural appearance and courtyard character associated with the existing range of buildings. The scale, footprint and arrangement of development remain closely aligned with the established built form, ensuring that the proposal does not result in harmful encroachment into the countryside or introduce an incongruous suburban form of development. The scheme instead seeks to reinforce the traditional rural vernacular through the use of simple massing, restrained architectural detailing and a palette of natural materials including stone and slate.

The proposal has also been developed to provide a substantially improved planning outcome when compared with the approved conversion scheme. In particular, the replacement dwellings will deliver enhanced standards of residential accommodation, improved energy efficiency, better integration with the surrounding landscape, and a more coherent architectural composition that responds positively to the wider farmstead setting.

The proposal has been prepared having regard to both national and local planning policy objectives, including the requirement to secure high-quality, sustainable and well-designed development in rural areas. Overall, the development represents a sensitive and considered redevelopment opportunity that builds positively upon the established Class Q fallback position while preserving the rural character and appearance of the site.

After conducting research of the site and surrounding area it has been noted that recent development sites have been approved within the area. Confirming the area is suitable for development. Please see some examples of approved planning in the area below:

PA24/06215 | Prior approval for proposed change of use of agricultural building to dwellinghouse | Barn B Gwarnick Mill Farm St Allen Truro TR4 9QU

PA24/07287 | Prior approval for proposed change of use from agriculture to 2 dwellings of 2 adjacent barns within an extensive range of farm buildings | Barn E And The Old Parlour Gwarnick Mill Farm St Allen Truro TR4 9QU

PA24/06514 | Application to determine if prior approval is required for a proposed: Change of use of Agricultural buildings to dwellinghouses (use Class C3) | Barn F Land North East Of Gwarnick Mill Farm St Allen Cornwall TR5 9QU

2.0 Site Context and Surroundings

The application site comprises Barn E at Gwarnick Mill Farm, located within the rural countryside setting of St Allen, to the east of Truro. The site forms part of an established agricultural complex associated with the wider farm holding, which historically functioned as a working rural enterprise and continues to exhibit the character and appearance of a traditional Cornish farmstead.

The surrounding area is characterised by dispersed rural development, agricultural buildings, traditional farmsteads and open pastureland, interspersed with mature hedgebanks, vegetation and areas of natural enclosure. Development within the locality is generally limited in scale and agricultural in appearance, reflecting the prevailing rural settlement pattern across this part of Cornwall.

Barn E occupies a contained position within the existing cluster of farm buildings and does not appear isolated within the wider countryside. The site is visually and functionally associated with the established farm complex, where agricultural structures already form an accepted and characteristic component of the landscape setting. Importantly, the principle of residential development at this location has already been established through the extant Class Q approval under application reference PA24/07287, which confirmed the acceptability of converting the existing agricultural buildings into two residential units.

The existing building itself is substantial in scale and arranged in a manner reflective of an agricultural courtyard typology, comprising interconnected barn structures and ancillary elements. This established arrangement strongly influences the design response of the proposed replacement dwellings, which seek to retain and reinforce the enclosed farmstead character of the site rather than introducing detached or suburban forms of development.

Access to the site is achieved via the existing farm track connecting to the nearby public highway, and the proposal continues to utilise this established access arrangement without requiring significant alteration to the surrounding highway infrastructure.

The site benefits from a strong degree of natural containment through the presence of existing Cornish hedging, established boundary vegetation and changes in landform, all of which contribute positively to local landscape character and help limit wider visibility from surrounding viewpoints. These existing landscape features create a well-defined rural enclosure and ensure that the site remains visually associated with the wider farmstead rather than appearing as isolated countryside development.

In landscape terms, the proposal is situated within a context where development is traditionally simple, functional and agricultural in appearance. The replacement dwellings have therefore been designed with careful regard to the established vernacular character of the site, ensuring that the scale, layout and material palette respond positively to the existing farm complex and remain sympathetic to the wider rural environment.

3.0 The Proposed Development.

This application seeks full planning permission for the construction of two replacement dwellings at Barn E, Gwarnick Mill Farm, following the prior approval for the conversion of the existing agricultural buildings into two residential units under Class Q permitted development rights. The proposal involves the demolition of the existing agricultural structures and the construction of a carefully designed replacement scheme that responds positively to the established farmstead character and wider rural setting.

The principle of residential use, including the subdivision of the site into two dwellings, has already been firmly established through the extant Class Q approval under application reference PA24/07287. The current proposal therefore represents an appropriate and logical evolution of that fallback position, providing an opportunity to deliver a significantly improved design solution that better responds to the character of the site, modern living standards, environmental performance requirements and long-term sustainability objectives.

The proposed dwellings have been intentionally designed to reflect the form, scale and arrangement of traditional agricultural buildings commonly found within rural Cornwall. Rather than appearing as detached suburban properties, the scheme adopts a restrained courtyard-style arrangement that reinforces the existing farmstead morphology and maintains the visual cohesion of the wider group of buildings. The layout and massing have been carefully composed to ensure that the development continues to read as a functional rural cluster, closely associated with the agricultural origins of the site.

Importantly, the replacement development remains closely aligned with the footprint, scale and established built envelope of the existing structures. The proposal therefore does not result in unacceptable encroachment into the countryside or introduce visually dominant forms of development beyond what has already been accepted through the Class Q fallback position.

Architecturally, the scheme has been developed using simple forms, clean rooflines and modest openings that reflect the restrained character of traditional agricultural buildings. The use of natural stone walling, slate roofing, timber fenestration and galvanised rainwater goods reinforces the authenticity of the rural design approach and ensures that the proposed dwellings integrate successfully within the wider landscape setting.

Internally, the dwellings have been designed to provide high-quality and functional accommodation with well-considered layouts that maximise natural light, outlook and residential amenity. The arrangement of living spaces and glazing has been carefully considered to create a positive relationship with the surrounding landscape while avoiding excessive domestication or visual intrusion when viewed from the surrounding countryside.

The proposal also incorporates a number of sustainability measures, including solar panels, air source heat pumps, permeable surfacing and enhanced landscaping works, all of which contribute toward reducing environmental impact and improving the long-term sustainability credentials of the development.

Overall, the proposed replacement dwellings represent a high-quality and policy-compliant form of rural development that builds positively upon the established Class Q approval. The scheme delivers a more coherent architectural composition, improved sustainability performance and enhanced integration with the surrounding landscape, while retaining the agricultural character and established built form of the existing farm complex.

4.0 Access & Movement

The application site at Barn E, Gwarnick Mill Farm benefits from an established access arrangement that serves the wider agricultural complex. Access to the site is achieved via the existing farm track to the west, which connects

directly to the local highway network, and no alterations to the public highway are required as part of the proposed development.

The proposed replacement dwellings will utilise this existing access arrangement, ensuring that there is no additional encroachment into the surrounding countryside and no alteration to the established movement patterns associated with the historic farmstead. The proposal therefore represents a continuation of the lawful access arrangements already accepted through the extant Class Q approval for the conversion of the buildings into two dwellings.

Vehicular access within the site has been carefully considered to ensure safe and practical movement for future occupiers whilst maintaining the rural and agricultural character of the setting. Sufficient space is provided within the site for parking and turning associated with both dwellings, with external areas designed using permeable and informal surfacing treatments that avoid the appearance of suburban domestic development.

The arrangement of the proposed development allows for clear and convenient pedestrian movement between parking areas, entrances and external amenity spaces. Access routes are direct and functional, reflecting the simple and practical character expected within a rural farmstead setting. The layout has also been designed to ensure that movement around the site remains efficient without compromising the visual integrity or agricultural appearance of the development.

Importantly, the access and movement arrangements remain modest in scale and do not introduce excessive domestic infrastructure, formalised lighting, signage or urbanising highway features that would appear incongruous within the countryside. The proposal therefore preserves the quiet rural character of the site and ensures that the development integrates appropriately within the established farm complex and wider landscape setting.

Overall, the proposed access arrangements are considered entirely appropriate for the scale and nature of the development and continue the established pattern of access and movement already associated with the site.

5.0 Landscape and Visual Impact

The proposed replacement dwellings at Barn E, Gwarnick Mill Farm have been developed with careful regard to the rural landscape setting and the need to ensure that the development integrates sensitively into its countryside context.

The site forms part of an established agricultural complex where farm buildings already contribute positively to the built character of the area. The proposal will therefore not introduce isolated or incongruous development into an undeveloped landscape, but instead remains closely associated with the existing farmstead grouping that defines this part of the rural environment.

A fundamental design principle of the proposal has been to retain the agricultural character, scale and visual composition of the existing building group. The proposed dwellings adopt a restrained courtyard-style arrangement reflective of traditional farmstead morphology, ensuring that the development continues to read as a cohesive rural cluster rather than a suburban form of residential development.

Importantly, the scale, footprint and overall massing of the replacement development remain closely aligned with the established built envelope of the existing structures. This approach significantly limits potential landscape impacts and ensures that the proposal does not result in harmful encroachment into the wider countryside beyond that already established through the extant Class Q approval.

The architectural treatment of the dwellings has been carefully considered to reinforce their integration within the surrounding landscape. The use of natural stone walling, slate roofing, timber fenestration and simple agricultural detailing reflects the established vernacular character of rural Cornwall and ensures that the proposed buildings remain visually sympathetic to the wider farm complex. The elevations avoid excessive domestic articulation or suburban features that could otherwise detract from the agricultural character of the site.

The site also benefits from a strong degree of natural enclosure through the presence of existing walling, established vegetation and surrounding landform, all of which help to filter views of the development from the surrounding landscape. These existing features will largely be retained and reinforced through an enhanced landscaping strategy that includes native planting, visual screen planting, flowering lawn areas and additional ecological enhancements.

The landscaping proposals have been designed to ensure that the development assimilates successfully into its surroundings over time, while maintaining the open and rural character of the site. Sensitive curtilage definition and permeable surfacing treatments further assist in avoiding suburbanisation and preserving the agricultural appearance of the farmstead setting.

Overall, the proposed replacement dwellings are considered to represent a sensitive and well-integrated form of rural development that preserves the landscape character of the area, respects the existing farmstead context, and delivers a significantly improved visual and architectural outcome when compared to the approved conversion scheme.

6.0 Landscaping and Ecological Considerations

The proposed replacement dwellings at Barn E, Gwarnick Mill Farm are supported by a sensitive and carefully considered landscaping strategy, designed to ensure that the development integrates successfully into its rural surroundings whilst maintaining and enhancing the established landscape character of the site.

The site already benefits from a strong degree of natural enclosure provided by existing Cornish hedging, established vegetation and the wider agricultural landscape setting. These features make an important contribution to the visual containment of the site, local landscape character and ecological connectivity within the surrounding countryside. A key objective of the proposal is therefore the retention and reinforcement of these existing landscape features wherever possible, ensuring that the development remains well integrated within the established farmstead environment.

The proposed landscaping scheme incorporates a range of enhancements intended to strengthen the site's relationship with the surrounding landscape and improve ecological value. These measures include additional native planting, flowering lawn areas, visual screen planting and the reinforcement of existing boundary treatments using traditional Cornish hedging. Together, these elements will assist in softening the appearance of the development over time and ensuring that the replacement dwellings assimilate naturally into their countryside setting.

The proposed curtilage treatment has been designed to remain appropriate to the agricultural character of the site. Rather than introducing formal suburban-style boundaries, the scheme utilises traditional and informal landscape treatments that maintain openness and preserve the rural appearance of the farmstead. This approach ensures that the development avoids unnecessary domestication and remains visually connected to the wider agricultural landscape.

It is acknowledged that the development is expected to fall within the scope of the de minimis exemption under the Biodiversity Gain Requirements (Exemptions) Regulations 2024, as the proposal is confined primarily to existing hardstanding and previously developed land and does not impact more than 25 square metres of habitat. Nevertheless, the applicant remains committed to delivering a development that responds positively to its environmental context through the retention of existing ecological features and the inclusion of proportionate landscape and habitat enhancements.

In addition, permeable surfacing materials will be utilised within parking and access areas where appropriate, supporting sustainable drainage principles and helping to maintain the informal and naturalistic appearance of the site.

Overall, the landscaping and ecological strategy has been designed to ensure that the proposed development preserves the rural character of the area, enhances visual integration, and delivers meaningful environmental improvements appropriate to the scale and nature of the proposal.

7.0 Sustainability and Energy Efficiency

The proposed replacement dwellings at Barn E, Gwarnick Mill Farm have been designed with sustainability and long-term environmental performance as key considerations. The redevelopment of the existing agricultural buildings provides an opportunity to deliver two highly efficient rural homes that significantly improve upon the limitations associated with the approved conversion approach, whilst remaining sensitive to the established farmstead character and wider countryside setting.

Both dwellings will be constructed to meet current Building Regulations standards and will incorporate high-quality insulated building envelopes designed to minimise heat loss and improve overall energy efficiency. This approach ensures that the development responds positively to national and local planning objectives which seek to support low-carbon development and promote more sustainable forms of housing within rural areas.

The proposal also incorporates a range of renewable and low-carbon technologies intended to reduce operational energy demand and reliance on fossil fuels. These measures include roof-mounted solar photovoltaic panels and air source heat pump systems, providing efficient and environmentally responsible heating and energy generation for the dwellings. Together, these technologies will contribute toward reducing carbon emissions over the lifetime of the development and improving its long-term sustainability credentials.

The architectural approach also reflects sustainable design principles through the retention of a compact and efficient built form that remains closely aligned with the footprint and arrangement of the existing structures. By maintaining the established building envelope and avoiding unnecessary expansion or excessive massing, the proposal limits its environmental impact whilst preserving the rural character of the site.

The use of durable, locally appropriate and natural materials, including stone walling and slate roofing, further supports the longevity and resilience of the development whilst reinforcing its integration within the surrounding landscape. These materials have been selected not only for their visual suitability, but also for their long-term durability and reduced maintenance requirements.

In addition, external areas associated with the development will utilise permeable and informal surfacing treatments where appropriate, supporting sustainable drainage principles and reducing surface water run-off. The wider landscaping strategy also contributes positively toward environmental sustainability through the incorporation of native planting, ecological enhancements and green infrastructure measures that strengthen the site's relationship with the surrounding countryside.

Overall, the proposal represents a sustainable form of rural development that delivers substantial improvements in environmental performance, energy efficiency and long-term resilience when compared to the approved conversion scheme, whilst remaining fully sympathetic to the agricultural character and landscape setting of the site.

8.0 Green Infrastructure

The proposed development has been designed with careful regard to the principles of green infrastructure, ensuring that the site continues to contribute positively to local landscape character, ecological connectivity and environmental quality.

The site forms part of an established rural farmstead enclosed by existing Cornish hedging, mature vegetation and areas of natural enclosure, all of which provide important visual, ecological and landscape functions within the wider countryside setting. These established features form part of the local green infrastructure network, acting as wildlife corridors and contributing positively toward the distinctive rural character of the area. A key objective of the proposal is therefore the retention and reinforcement of these existing landscape features wherever possible, ensuring continuity within the surrounding ecological framework.

In addition to the retention of existing boundary features, the proposal incorporates a comprehensive landscaping strategy including supplementary native planting, flowering lawn areas, visual screen planting and reinforcement of traditional Cornish hedging. These measures are intended to strengthen biodiversity value, improve ecological resilience and enhance the assimilation of the development into its countryside setting.

The landscaping approach has been intentionally designed to remain informal and agricultural in character, avoiding ornamental or suburban treatments that would appear visually intrusive within the rural environment. The proposed curtilage arrangements and boundary treatments ensure that the development remains visually and functionally connected to the wider farmstead and surrounding landscape, rather than appearing as a detached suburban enclave.

Permeable surfacing materials will also be utilised where appropriate throughout parking and access areas, supporting sustainable drainage principles and contributing positively toward water management objectives within the site. Collectively, these measures ensure that the proposal not only preserves existing green infrastructure assets but also enhances the environmental quality and ecological function of the site at a local level.

Overall, the proposal has been carefully developed to respond positively to its environmental context and accords with the objectives of Policy 23 of the Cornwall Local Plan, which seeks to protect and enhance green infrastructure networks, landscape character and ecological connectivity throughout Cornwall's rural areas.

9.0 Planning Policy

The proposed replacement dwellings at Barn E, Gwarnick Mill Farm have been carefully developed to deliver a high-quality and sustainable form of rural development that aligns with both national and local planning policy objectives. The proposal has been prepared having full regard to the established Class Q fallback position, the agricultural character of the site, and the requirement for development within the countryside to remain proportionate, well-designed and environmentally sensitive.

At a national level, the proposal accords with the overarching objectives of the National Planning Policy Framework (NPPF). In particular, the development supports sustainable development in accordance with Paragraph 11, which establishes the presumption in favour of development proposals that contribute positively to economic, social and environmental objectives.

The proposal also reflects the NPPF's emphasis on achieving well-designed places under Paragraph 131, together with the requirement under Paragraph 135 for development to be visually attractive, sympathetic to local character, and responsive to the surrounding built and landscape context. The proposed dwellings have been intentionally designed to retain the appearance and form of a traditional agricultural building group, utilising simple massing, high-quality natural materials and restrained detailing that reinforce local distinctiveness and preserve the rural character of the farmstead setting.

The proposal is also strongly aligned with the policy framework set out within the Cornwall Local Plan: Strategic Policies 2010–2030.

Policy 2 (Spatial Strategy) supports development that is appropriately located and proportionate in scale. In this case, the proposal is situated within an established farm complex where the principle of residential development, including the creation of two dwellings, has already been accepted through the extant Class Q approval. The

development therefore represents an appropriate continuation of an established lawful fallback position rather than the introduction of isolated new development within the countryside.

Policy 7 (Housing in the Countryside) requires housing proposals outside settlement boundaries to be of an appropriate scale, relate positively to their surroundings and avoid unjustified encroachment into the rural landscape. The proposed replacement dwellings remain closely aligned with the footprint, scale and arrangement of the existing buildings, ensuring that the development remains visually contained within the established built envelope of the farmstead and does not result in harmful suburban expansion into the surrounding countryside.

The proposal also accords with Policy 12 (Design), which seeks high-quality development that respects and reinforces local character. The scheme has been specifically designed to maintain the agricultural courtyard character of the site through the use of traditional forms, simple rooflines and locally appropriate materials including natural stone and slate. The overall composition avoids excessive domestic features and instead delivers a coherent rural design solution that integrates successfully within the wider landscape setting.

In environmental terms, the proposal is consistent with Policy 23 (Natural Environment), which seeks to protect and enhance Cornwall's landscapes, ecological networks and green infrastructure assets. The scheme retains existing Cornish hedging and vegetation, incorporates extensive native planting and ecological enhancements, and utilises permeable surfacing treatments to support sustainable drainage and environmental integration. The landscaping strategy has been designed to ensure that the development responds positively to its environmental context whilst preserving the open and agricultural character of the site.

The proposal also supports national and local objectives relating to climate change mitigation and sustainable construction. In accordance with NPPF Paragraph 152, the development incorporates renewable and low-carbon technologies including solar panels and air source heat pumps, alongside high-performance building construction standards intended to reduce operational energy demand and improve long-term environmental performance.

Overall, the proposed replacement dwellings represent a policy-compliant and sustainable form of rural development that delivers a significantly improved design outcome when compared with the approved conversion scheme, whilst preserving the character, appearance and environmental quality of the wider countryside setting.

10.0 Conclusion

The proposed replacement dwellings at Barn E, Gwarnick Mill Farm represent a carefully considered and sustainable redevelopment opportunity founded upon the established principle of residential development already accepted through the extant Class Q approval under application reference PA24/07287. Importantly, the fallback position confirms not only the acceptability of residential use at the site, but also the principle of creating two dwellings within the existing agricultural complex. This fallback position is therefore a highly material consideration in the determination of the application.

The key planning consideration is consequently whether the proposed replacement scheme results in any greater planning harm when assessed against the development plan and the wider objectives of national planning policy. In this instance, the proposal is considered to deliver a significantly improved planning and design outcome when compared with the approved conversion scheme.

The proposed development remains closely aligned with the established footprint, scale and built form of the existing agricultural structures, ensuring that the replacement dwellings remain proportionate to their setting and do not result in harmful encroachment into the surrounding countryside. The scheme preserves the agricultural courtyard character of the farmstead and has been specifically designed to avoid suburbanisation through the use of restrained architectural detailing, traditional materials and sensitive landscape treatment.

The proposal fully accords with the relevant provisions of the Cornwall Local Plan, particularly Policy 2 (Spatial Strategy), Policy 7 (Housing in the Countryside), Policy 12 (Design) and Policy 23 (Natural Environment). The development represents a proportionate and policy-compliant form of rural redevelopment that integrates successfully into its landscape setting whilst preserving local character and environmental quality.

At a national level, the proposal also aligns with the objectives of the National Planning Policy Framework, including the presumption in favour of sustainable development set out under Paragraph 11, the requirement to achieve high-quality and well-designed places under Paragraphs 131 and 135, and the promotion of low-carbon and sustainable development consistent with Paragraph 152.

The incorporation of renewable technologies, enhanced landscaping, green infrastructure measures and high-performance construction standards further demonstrates the proposal's commitment to long-term environmental sustainability and responsible rural development.

Overall, the proposed replacement dwellings represent a logical and policy-compliant evolution of the established Class Q fallback position, delivering a substantially improved architectural, environmental and landscape outcome without resulting in additional countryside, visual or landscape harm. The proposal therefore accords fully with the development plan and national planning policy, and it is respectfully submitted that full planning permission should be granted.